Version 1.1 | 2026-10-24 | Current

Records Management Policy

The Second World War Archive Record Management Policy

1. **Purpose and Scope**

   1.1 Purpose

   The Second World War Archive (hereinafter 'the Archive') holds one of the most historically significant collections of records documenting the 1939-1945 conflict. This Records Management Policy (RMP) ensures that all materials entrusted to the Archive, whether acquired through donation, transfer, digitization, or institutional collection, are managed thoroughly and with the integrity and care that such irreplaceable history demands.

   This policy establishes binding standards for how records are created, received, classified, stored, accessed, retained, and either disposed of or permanently preserved. It ensures that the Archive meets its obligations under applicable archival law, data protection legislation, and accepted international standards for archival practice.

   The core purposes of this policy are to:

   - Safeguard the physical and intellectual integrity of all archival holdings.
   - Ensure that access to sensitive records is managed responsibly and equitably. This includes records containing to personal, intelligence and operational data.

- Provide clear and consistent guidance to all staff, researchers, and partners who interact with the Archive's records.
- Ensure legal and regulatory compliance, including with data protection and freedom of information requests.
- Support the long-term preservation and accessibility of the Archive's collections for future generations.

1.2 Scope

This policy applies to all records held by or on behalf of the Second World War Archive, regardless of format (paper, photographic, film, audio, digital, or artifact), origin (domestic, Allied, Axis, or neutral, or physical location (on-site repository, off-site storage, or digital systems).

It applies to all individuals who create, handle, process, access, or manage records in any capacity. This includes, but is not limited to, permanent and temporary staff, volunteers, contracted researchers, visiting scholars, digitization partners, and IT service providers.

Records held jointly with partner institutions are subject to this policy in addition to any applicable joint custody agreements. Where conflicts arise between this policy and a partner agreement, the matter shall be escalated to the Records Manager, and if necessary, to the Archive Director for resolution.

2. Key Definitions

The following terms are used throughout this policy and carry the meanings defined below. Consistent use of these definitions is essential to the correct interpretation and application of all provisions contained herein.

Term	Definition
Record	Any item, in any format, that documents an activity, decision, transaction, or event relating to the Second World War or to the administration of the Archive itself. Includes but not limited to documents, photographs, maps, diaries, signals intelligence, transcripts, oral history recordings, artifacts, and digital files.
Archival Record	A record of enduring historical, evidential, or research value that has been formally accessioned into the permanent collection. Archival records are not subject to routine disposal.
Active Record	A record currently in regular use by staff or researchers in the conduct of the Archive business or research activities.
Inactive Record	A record no longer in regular use but retained for reference, legal, or compliance purposes pending a disposal or transfer decision.
Classification	The process of assigning a sensitivity level to a record to determine appropriate handling, access, and storage requirements.
Retention Period	The defined length of time a record must be kept before it is reviewed for disposal, transfer to permanent preservation, or continued retention.
Appraisal	The systematic evaluation of records to determine their historical, evidential, and research value, and consequently whether they should be permanently preserved or disposed of.
Disposition	The action taken at the end of a retention period: permanent archiving, transfer to another institution, or secure destruction.
Accession	The formal process by which new records are received, documented, and incorporated into the Archive's holdings.
Finding Aid	A descriptive document that provides information about a collection which enables researchers to identify and locate relevant records.

Restricted Record	A record to which access is limited by reason of sensitivity, ongoing legal proceedings, donor agreement, or data protection requirements.
Personal Data	Any information relating to an identifiable living individual, as defined under applicable data protection legislation.
Digital Preservation	The set of managed activities necessary to ensure continued access to digital materials for as long as they are needed.
Chain of Custody	The chronological documentation establishing the seizure, control, transfer, analysis, and handling of records from their creation or acquisition to the present.

3. Roles and Responsibilities

Effective records management depends upon clearly defined responsibilities at every level of the organization. The following roles carry specific obligations under this policy. All individuals in these roles are required to familiarize themselves with this document upon appointment and to seek guidance from the Records Manager whenever uncertainty arises.

3.1 Archive Director

- Holds ultimate institutional accountability for records management across the Archive.
- Approves and authorizes this policy and all subsequent revisions.
- Ensures adequate resources are allocated to records management functions. These include, but are not limited to, financial, staffing, and technical.
- Acts as the final escalation point for disputes regarding access, classification, or disposal decisions.

- Signs off on the permanent disposal of any record assessed as being of potential historical significance.

3.2 Records Manager

- Holds day-to-day operational responsibility for all records management activities.
- Maintains and enforces this policy, and coordinates its periodic review.
- Oversees the classification, retention scheduling, and disposition of all records.
- Conducts and coordinates annual compliance audits and reports findings to the Archive Director.
- Manages the Archive's records management systems, including cataloging databases and access control mechanisms.
- Provides training and guidance to all staff on records management procedures and obligations.
- Liaises with legal counsel, data protection officers, and external regulators as required.
- Maintains the Archive's Records Retention Schedule, updating it as necessary to reflect legislative or policy changes.

3.3 Department Heads and Collection Managers

- Responsible for the proper management of all records within their respective collections or operational areas.
- Ensure that staff under their supervision comply fully with this policy.
- Conduct regular reviews of record holdings in their area to identify materials approaching the end of their retention period.

- Submit disposal or transfer recommendations to the Records Manager in a timely manner.
- Ensure that all new acquisitions are promptly reported to the Records Manager for formal accession.
- Notify the Records Manager immediately in the event of any loss, damage, or unauthorized access to records.

3.4 Archivists and Cataloging Staff

- Apply classification markings to all records in accordance with the scheme defined in Section 4.
- Prepare and maintain finding aids and other descriptive metadata to the standards set by the Records Manager.
- Handle all records in accordance with applicable conservation and preservation guidelines.
- Flag to their Department Head any records that appear to be misclassified, damaged, or lacking provenance documentation.

3.5 Researchers and External Users

- Must register with the Archive and agree to the Terms of Access before handling any record.
- Are responsible for using records only for the purposes declared at registration and in accordance with any restrictions applied to specific items.
- Must report any damage to or accidental misplacement of records to a member of staff immediately.

- May not reproduce, photograph, or publish any record without obtaining the appropriate reproduction or publication permission from the Archive.

3.6 IT and Digital Infrastructure Staff

- Responsible for the security, integrity, and availability of all digital systems used to store or manage records.
- Must implement and maintain access controls as specified by the Records Manager.
- Provide timely support for digital preservation activities, including format migration, backup, and disaster recovery.
- Notify the Records Manager immediately in the event of any cybersecurity incident affecting archival systems.

4. Records Classification and Retention

4.1 Classification Framework

All records held by the Archive must be assigned to one of the following classification levels. Classification determines the level of access control, storage requirements, and handling procedures applicable to each record. Initial classification is assigned by the accessioning archivist and reviewed at the first scheduled retention review.

The four classification levels are as follows:

OPEN: Records freely accessible to registered researchers and, where applicable, to the general public via online catalogs or public reading rooms. These records contain no personal data relating to living individuals, no operationally sensitive intelligence, and no material subject to donor restriction.

RESTRICTED: Records accessible only to registered researchers who have demonstrated a legitimate scholarly, educational, or administrative purpose. These records may contain personal data relating to living individuals, names of intelligence sources or operatives, sensitive personnel records, or information subject to specific donor agreements.

CONFIDENTIAL: Records accessible only to senior Archive staff and, where relevant, approved external parties (e.g., government agencies or legal representatives). These records typically contain classified intelligence material, records of covert operations, or information whose disclosure could cause harm to identifiable individuals or to ongoing national security interests.

SEALED: Records not accessible to any external party without the specific written authorization of the Archive Director, in consultation with legal counsel, and where required, the relevant government department. Sealed records are held under the highest level of physical and digital security. A review of sealed status must occur at least every ten years.

4.2 Records Retention Schedule

The following retention periods apply to the principal categories of records held by the Archive. Retention periods commence from the date of creation or, in the case of acquired records, from the date of accession. All retention periods are subject to review if there is a material change in legislation, research value, or donor agreement terms.

At the end of the retention period, records are subject to formal appraisal (see Section 6) prior to any disposal decision.

Record Category	Retention Period	Notes
Operational field reports & unit war diaries	Permanent	Archival preservation. Core historical documentation of military operations.
Intelligence & signals intercepts (ULTRA, etc.)	Permanent; automatic declassification at 25 years from date of origin, with specific exemptions. Source identity records may extend to 75 years.	Automatic declassification at 25 years. Exemptions require ISCAP notification. Review coordinated with NARA National Declassification Center.
Personal service records (military)	Permanent; Open to the public 62 years after the service members separation; Prior to the 62 years, restricted to veteran or next-of kin	Includes records relating to auxiliary services, munitions work, and civil defense.
Personal service records (civilian war work)	Permanent; Open to the public 62 years after the service members separation; Prior to the 62 years, restricted to veteran or next-of kin	Includes civilian federal employees engaged in war work. Includes records relating to auxiliary services, munitions work, and civil defense.
Prisoner of war records	Permanent	Subject to strict data protection controls while subjects or direct descendants may be living.
Photographs & film footage	Permanent	All photographic and film records are preserved permanently. Personal identifiers reviewed at accession.
Maps & cartographic records	Permanent	Operational and strategic maps preserved in perpetuity.
Oral history interviews	Permanent	With reference to specific consent terms agreed at the time of recording.
Donated personal papers & correspondence	Permanent	Subject to donor agreements. Restrictions lifted per agreed schedule.

Administrative records (Archives operations)	10 years	Non-permanent; subject to appraisal at 10 years. Significant policy records permanently retained.
Researcher access & registration records	7 years after last access	Retained for security, audit, and legal compliance purposes.
Reproductions & publication permissions	10 years after expiry of agreement	Retained for legal reference
Digitization project records	Permanent (master files); 10 years (project admin)	Master digital files preserved permanently; project correspondence subject to standard admin retention.
Accession & deaccession records	Permanent	All records of acquisitions and disposals retained permanently as part of institutional history.

NOTE: Retention periods for intelligence records are additionally subject to review under any applicable national security legislation in force at the time of review.

5. Security and Access Control

5.1 Physical Security

All physical records held by the Archive are stored in environmentally controlled conditions appropriate to their format and conservation needs. Access to storage areas is restricted to authorized staff only, and all repositories are fitted with the following baseline security measures:

- Locked, fire-rated storage for all paper, photographic, and film records.
- Video monitoring of all repository entrances, reading rooms, and digitization workspaces. Footage needs to be retained for a minimum of 90 days
- Intruder detection and fire suppression systems tested at least annually.

- Keycard or biometric access controls for all restricted storage areas with access logs. Logs need to be maintained and reviewed quarterly by the Records Manager.
- A formal visitor log maintained for all individuals entering restricted areas.

CONFIDENTIAL and SEALED records are held in a dedicated secure vault separate from the general repository, accessible only to the Records Manager, Archive Director, and such individuals as are specifically authorized in writing.

5.2 Digital Security

- All digital archival systems are protected by role-based access control (RBAC) in accordance with NIST SP 800-53r5 (Security and Privacy Controls for Information Systems and Organizations), specifically the AC (Access Control) control family. Access rights are assigned by the Records Manager in accordance with the principle of least privilege.
- User access credentials are reviewed and updated quarterly or immediately upon a change in employment status.
- All digital systems containing RESTRICTED, CONFIDENTIAL, or SEALED records are encrypted at rest and in transit using current best-practice encryption standards.
- Digital records are stored on dedicated archival servers with no public internet access. Remote access, where operationally necessary, is permitted only via approved encrypted VPN connections.
- All access to digital records systems is logged. Logs are reviewed monthly by IT staff and quarterly by the Records Manager.

- Regular penetration testing of archival digital systems is conducted at least biannually by an independent external provider.

5.3 Research and Access Procedures

- All researchers must complete a formal registration process before accessing any Archive record. Registration requires proof of identity, details of the research purpose, and agreement to the Archive's Terms of Access.
- OPEN records may be accessed in the public reading room during advertised opening hours, and are subject to standard handling guidelines.
- RESTRICTED records may be accessed only by registered researchers who have submitted a written access request specifying the records required and the purpose of access. The Records Manager must approve all such requests.
- CONFIDENTIAL records are not accessible to external researchers except in exceptional circumstances and with the written authorization of the Archive Director. Government or legal access requests must be accompanied by the appropriate statutory instrument or court order.
- SEALED records are not available to any external party except by order of a court or equivalent legal authority, or by the specific written authorization of the Archive Director in consultation with the relevant government department.
- All researchers handling physical records must work under staff supervision in the designated reading room. No records may be removed from the reading room under any circumstances.

6. Disposal and Permanent Archiving

6.1 Appraisal Process

When a record reaches the end of its defined retention period, it must undergo formal appraisal before any disposal decision is made. Appraisal is the structured process by which the Archive evaluates a record's ongoing historical, evidential, legal, and research value.

The appraisal process proceeds as follows:

- The relevant Department Head or Collection Manager identifies records approaching the end of their retention period and notifies the Records Manager at least three months in advance.
- The Records Manager assigns a qualified archivist to conduct the appraisal, using the Archive's standard Appraisal Assessment Form.
- The appraisal considers: evidential value; informational value; uniqueness; relationship to other holdings; researcher demand; physical condition; and any legal, donor, or access restrictions.
- The appraiser submits a written recommendation to the Records Manager, noting permanent preservation, extended retention with a review date, transfer to another institution, or secure disposal.
- The Records Manager reviews and approves or modifies the recommendation. Recommendations for the disposal of any record assessed as potentially significant must be countersigned by the Archive Director.
- All appraisal decisions and their rationale are documented and retained permanently as part of the Archive's institutional record.

6.2 Secure Disposal

Where appraisal determines that a record has no further value warranting retention, the following disposal procedures apply:

- Paper records: Cross-cut shredding producting particles no larger than 1mm x 5mm, in accordance with NSA/CSS Evaluated Products List (EPL) shredder specifications and NARA CUI Destruction Guidance (ISOO CUI Notice 2017-02), conducted by Archive staff or a NAID AAA-certified contractor. A certificate of Destruction is obtained and retained permanently.
- Photographic and film records: Destruction by an approved specialist contractor, with documentation confirming secure disposal.
- Digital records: Secure deletion using approved data erasure software meeting NIST SP 800-88r2 standards, or physical destruction of storage media where software erasure is insufficient. A Certificate of Destruction is retained permanently.
- CONFIDENTIAL and SEALED records: Disposal is carried out only by the Records Manager or designated senior archivist, in the presence of at least one witness. A witnessed destruction certificate is completed and filed.

No record may be disposed of until a completed appraisal form and, where applicable, written authorization from the Archive Director has been obtained and filed.

6.2 Transfer to Permanent Preservation

Records identified during appraisal for permanent preservation are formally transferred to the Archive's permanent collection or, where appropriate, to a partner institution, national archive, or digital preservation repository.

- Physical transfer is accompanied by a full transfer schedule documenting the contents, condition, and chain of custody of all items transferred.
- Digital transfer follows agreed preservation formats (e.g., TIFF, PDF/A, or WAV as appropriate) and is accompanied by full metadata in the Archive's standard schema.
- All transfers are recorded in the Archive's accession register. The permanent record of the transfer itself is retained indefinitely.

7. Compliance Requirements and Audit Procedures

7.1 Legislative and Regulatory Framework

The Archive's records management practices must comply with all applicable legislation and regulatory standards. Key legal and regulatory requirements include:

- The Privacy Act of 1974 (5 USC 552a), which governs the collection, maintenance, and disclosure of records containing personal information about identifiable individuals, including archival records transferred to or held by the Archive.
- The Freedom of Information Act (5USC 552) includes timely responses to valid access requests and maintenance of a publication scheme.
- The Public Records Acts or equivalent national archival legislation applicable to the Archive's jurisdiction.
- Applicable national security legislation governing the retention and disclosure of classified or intelligence-related records, including Executive Order 13526 (Classified National Security Information) and any implementing directives.

- The Federal Records Act (44 USC Chapters 21, 29, 31, 33) and applicable National Archives and Records Administration (NARA) regulations, including General Records Schedules and NARA-approved disposition authorities.
- International standards for archival practice, including ISO 15489 (Records Management) and ISO 14721 (Open Archival Information System Reference Model), are incorporated into the Archive's operational standards.
- Donor agreements and any other contractual obligations arising from the Archive's acquisition activities.

The Records Manager is responsible for monitoring changes in legislative and regulatory requirements and updating this policy and the Records Retention Schedule accordingly. Legal advice must be sought wherever there is uncertainty about a compliance obligation.

7.2 Internal Audit Program

The Archive conducts a structured program of records management audits to verify compliance with the policy and to identify areas for improvement. The audit program comprises:

- Annual Compliance Audit: Conducted each year by the Records Manager, covering a systematic sample of at least 15% of record holdings across all classification levels. The audit assesses the accuracy of classification markings; adherence to retention schedules; physical and digital storage conditions; access log integrity; and completeness of accession and disposal records.
- Triennial Comprehensive Review: Every three years, a comprehensive audit of all holdings is conducted, including an external component carried out by

an independent specialist with expertise in archival records management. The findings of this review are reported to the Archive's governing board or equivalent oversight body.

- Incident Audits: Any breach of this policy, including unauthorized access, loss, theft, or damage to records, triggers an immediate targeted audit of the affected systems or holdings, conducted by the Records Manager in consultation with relevant staff.

7.3 Audit Reporting and Follow-Up

- A written audit report is produced following each annual audit. The report summarizes findings, identifies any instances of non-compliance, and proposes specific remedial actions with assigned owners and completion deadlines.
- Audit reports are presented to the Archive Director within 30 days of the audit's completion.
- Remedial actions must be completed within the timeframes specified in the audit report. Completion is confirmed in writing to the Records Manager.
- All audit reports are retained permanently as part of the Archive's institutional record.
- Significant and repeated non-compliance is treated as a disciplinary matter and may result in formal action in accordance with the Archive's human resource policies.

8. Policy Review and Update

8.1 Scheduled Review

The policy will be reviewed in full on a biennial basis (every two years) from the date of its adoption. The Records Manager is responsible for initiating and coordinating the review process, which will include:

- A comprehensive assessment of any changes in applicable legislation or regulation since the last review.
- An evaluation of changes in archival best practice, including relevant updates to ISO standards.
- Review of findings from audit reports produced in the review period.
- Consultation with the Department Heads, Collection Managers, and relevant legal and data protection advisors.
- Assessment of any emerging risks, including digital preservation risks, cybersecurity developments, or changes in the Archive's holdings or operations, that may require policy adjustment.

8.2 Interim Amendments

Where a material change in legislation, an organizational change, or an identified risk requires policy amendment before the scheduled review, the Records Manager may propose an interim amendment to the Archive Directory. Interim amendments must be:

- Documented with a clear explanation of the reason for the amendments.
- Approved in writing by the Archive Director
- Communicated to all relevant staff within five working days of approval.
- Incorporated into the next scheduled full review.

8.3 Version Control

Each version of this policy is assigned a version number and an effective date. Superseded versions are retained permanently in the Archive's policy register. All staff are notified of new versions upon their adoption, and the Records Manager is responsible for ensuring that only the current version is displayed or distributed.